The Scopes ‘Monkey’ Trial — Bryan and Darrow

Dayton, Tennessee · July 20, 1925 · seventh day of testimony · excerpt

Source: State of Tennessee v. John Thomas Scopes, trial transcript, Day 7 (July 20, 1925), via Famous Trials (Prof. Douglas O. Linder, UMKC School of Law). Public domain.

In 1925 Tennessee passed the Butler Act, making it illegal to teach human evolution in public schools. The American Civil Liberties Union recruited high-school teacher John Scopes to challenge the law. The trial in Dayton became a national spectacle — radio-broadcast, press-saturated — between Clarence Darrow for the defense and three-time presidential nominee William Jennings Bryan for the prosecution. On the seventh day, Darrow called Bryan himself as a witness on biblical literalism. Scopes was convicted (later overturned on a technicality), but the cultural moment damaged the fundamentalist movement.

> *Connect: The Scopes Trial’s fundamentalism-vs-modernism split echoes the 2nd Great Awakening (Class 14). How is 1920s religion different from 1830s religion?*

Key Passages

Darrow questions Bryan on Jonah

> Q—But do you believe He made them—that He made such a fish and that it was big enough to swallow Jonah? A—Yes, sir. Let me add: One miracle is just as easy to believe as another Q—Just as hard? A—It is hard to believe for you, but easy for me. … Q—Perfectly easy to believe that Jonah swallowed the whale? A—If the Bible said so; the Bible doesn’t make as extreme statements as evolutionists do

On the age of the earth

> But I think it would be just as easy for the kind of God we believe in to make the earth in six days as in six years or in 6,000,000 years or in 600,000,000 years. I do not think it important whether we believe one or the other. Q—Do you think those were literal days? A—My impression is they were periods, but I would not attempt to argue as against anybody who wanted to believe in literal days.

Bryan, on Darrow’s purpose

> The only purpose Mr. Darrow has is to slur at the Bible, but I will answer his question. … I want the world to know that this man, who does not believe in a God, is trying to use a court in Tennesseee … Darrow—I object to your statement. I am exempting you on your fool ideas that no intelligent Christian on earth believes.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The 1920s culture war between modernism and religious fundamentalism; Tennessee's Butler Act (1925) banned teaching human evolution in public schools.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	The jury and the courtroom crowd, but really the national audience following through newspapers and the first radio broadcast of a trial.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Clarence Darrow, a defense lawyer and modernist questioning religious literalism, versus William Jennings Bryan, a fundamentalist and former Populist hero.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ — change over time in 1920s culture: Identify ONE specific cultural tension the Scopes Trial reveals.
2. Why is the Scopes Trial often called a turning point in modernism vs. fundamentalism — even though Scopes lost?
3. Compare urban vs. rural responses to the trial.